

Developments after the opponent's intervention

How to go on when an opponent comes in: whoever bids now does so freely.

1 Forced and free bids

Without interference, responder must keep the bidding open even with 5 points: opener might hold 20. After an overcall opener gets another chance anyway, so any bid is a **free bid**.

A free bid always shows a hand that is happy to bid: more than the minimum.

a

With 4–5 points and nothing special, **pass**.

b

Notrump is no longer a forced response: it promises a **stopper** in their suit.

c

Every new suit shows **at least five cards**.

d

Two new calls: the **double** (over a suit) and the **redouble** (over a double).

1♦ – 1♠ – ?

♠ Jxx ♥ Kx ♦ Qxxx ♣ Qxxx

Pass: without the overcall you would bid 2♦. Now you don't have to: with 7 ordinary points, let partner decide.

2 After their double

The redouble (11+ points, any shape) is the only strong call. You describe the hand on the next round.

New suit not forcing: a proposed contract, at least 5–6 good cards, fewer than 11 points

Raises as without the double, but always with fewer than 11 points

1NT 7–10 points, happy to play it, with stoppers in the doubler's suits

1♥ – Double – ?

♠ Kx ♥ Jx ♦ AQx ♣ KQJ10xx

Redouble, not 2♣: after the double, 2♣ would show fewer than 11 points.

1♥ – Double – ?

♠ xx ♥ Jx ♦ xxx ♣ KQ10xxx

2♣: "I'd be happy to play 2♣." A good six-card suit, not enough to redouble.

3 After a suit overcall

A new suit is forcing, with five or more cards. The double shows 8+ points (unlimited) and seeks a 4-4 fit.

1♦ – 1♠ – ?

♠ xx ♥ AQxxx ♦ Qx ♣ KJxx

2♥: a five-card suit and enough points for the two level.

Double: "I'd like to play in one of the other suits." With the points to bid but not the length for a new suit, it asks opener to bid another suit, or notrump if possible.

Raises don't change: you don't need five cards to raise.

4 What opener does

With ordinary hands, balanced or not, opener passes; with four-card support, opener raises by strength.

Opener bids freely only with an unbalanced minimum hand holding an **excellent one-suiter** or a **two-suiter with at least 10 cards**; with 18–20 balanced and a stopper, opener bids notrump at the lowest level. A suit rebid freely is always a really good suit.

1♦ – 1♥ – 1♠ – 2♥ – ?

♠ Jx ♥ Kx ♦ AQxxx ♣ Qxxx

Pass: a minimum two-suiter, in points and in shape, is an ordinary hand.

1♣ – Pass – 1♥ – 1♠ – ?

♠ AQxx ♥ x ♦ Qx ♣ KQxxxx

Pass: an unbalanced minimum, but no outstanding suit and no fit.